
A
Prayer
Between
Seasons

WHISPERS OF GRACE

A Prayer Between Seasons

Book IV of Whispers of Grace

From The House of Christ Garden

A Prayer Between Seasons

Book IV of Whispers of Grace

From The House of Christ Garden

© 2026 From The House of Christ Garden. All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Characters, incidents, and locations are used imaginatively. Any resemblance to actual persons or events is coincidental.

First edition · 2026

DEDICATION

For Those Beginning Again

For anyone who has carried a grief through many seasons and is learning that love may still make room for tomorrow.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

On Faith and the Passing Year

This story approaches Christian faith as a practice of attention, community, and truthful prayer. It does not suggest that suffering is deserved, that faith guarantees an outcome, or that grief follows a predictable timetable. The village and its people are fictional; their ordinary choices are the heart of this book.

PROLOGUE

The Open Gate

On the morning she returned to Bellwether, the last snow was leaving the fields in narrow white seams. Mara Vale watched them through the bus window, each seam holding its shape a little longer in the shade of a hedge. She had not visited the village in twelve years. She had told people there was no reason to come back, though there had been a hundred reasons and she had feared nearly all of them.

Her mother's house waited at the end of Orchard Lane, where the road narrowed between stone walls. The key was in Mara's pocket, warm from her hand. Her mother had died in October, but the estate had taken months to settle, and Mara had made the delays sound practical. At the last bend she saw the chapel gate: one pillar worn pale, the other dark with moss. Beyond it stood the small building where her mother had sung on Sundays, where Mara had once prayed for something she never received.

She had come to empty a house and leave before spring. She carried one suitcase and a list of tasks. She had not expected the gate to be open.

CHAPTER 01

The House at the End of the Lane

The first thing Mara noticed was that her mother had left the kitchen clock running. Its hands moved with a steady little click above the window, as though the room had not been unoccupied for months. The second thing was the smell: dried lavender, furniture polish, and the faint mineral damp of an old house in winter. She put her suitcase beside the table and opened the curtains. Across the back garden, apple trees held their bare arms over an uneven lawn.

A blue envelope lay beneath the fruit bowl. Her name was written in the familiar, upright hand. Mara sat down before opening it. Inside was a short note asking her to keep the house until the first harvest, if she could. There was no explanation, only a sentence about the garden needing someone to listen to it. Her mother had always written as though the world could answer if a person waited long enough.

Mara folded the paper sharply. Her train ticket home was booked for Friday. She had work waiting, an apartment in the city, and a life organized around not needing anyone. Her mother's request was unreasonable. Yet she set the note beside the clock rather than in the rubbish.

That evening a knock came at the door. An elderly man stood outside with a basket of bread and a wool cap pulled over his ears. He introduced himself as Peter Ash, the chapel caretaker. He had known her mother for forty years. Mara remembered him only as a tall figure who carried hymnbooks. He offered the bread without asking how she felt. When she thanked him, he glanced at the overgrown garden and said, 'Your mother kept the gate unlatched for anyone who needed a quiet place.' Mara told him she would be leaving soon. He nodded as though he had heard something different: not a decision, but a fear.

CHAPTER 02

A Gate That Would Not Close

The chapel gate had swollen during the winter and would not meet its latch. Mara discovered this while taking a morning walk she had not planned. She pushed the iron leaves together, felt them resist, and stepped back. A woman on the path behind her said that forcing it would only crack the old hinge. She was June Ellery, the village school librarian, with rain in her hair and a shopping bag full of books.

June recognized Mara immediately. They had been girls together, though not friends. In school Mara had been quick with answers and quicker to leave a room before anyone asked a question about home. June remembered her mother, Ruth, as the person who brought soup when June's father was ill. Mara had no reply to this version of Ruth. In the city, people spoke of the dead in formal summaries; here, they carried individual memories that seemed to belong to them.

Inside the chapel, sunlight fell through plain glass onto wooden benches. No one was there. The building smelled of wax and cold stone. On the noticeboard hung a schedule of practical things: a food cupboard, a Wednesday reading hour, a list of volunteers to visit people who lived alone. Mara had expected religion to meet her with words. Instead she

found a pencil tied to a clipboard and an empty box waiting for donations.

June asked whether Mara would help mend the gate before the Easter gathering. Mara said she knew nothing about hinges. June smiled. 'Neither do I. Peter knows. We can hold things while he works.' The simplicity of the invitation unsettled her. She could refuse a sermon. She did not know how to refuse the offer of a small, ordinary task.

CHAPTER 03

The Shape of Absence

At night Mara sorted the upstairs cupboards. Her mother had kept the practical records in labeled folders: taxes, repairs, prescriptions, receipts for groceries. Between them were postcards Mara had sent from cities where she had lived, each one preserved in a sleeve. Mara remembered writing them quickly, often in airport lounges, offering facts about the weather instead of details about herself.

In a bedroom drawer she found a photograph of her younger brother, Eli, at sixteen. He was laughing in the garden, holding a broken watering can above his head. The image stopped her. Eli had died that winter after an accident on the road beyond the village. Mara had been twenty. She had prayed beside his hospital bed with a certainty that embarrassed her now. When he died, she concluded that prayer had been a foolish bargain and that the chapel, which had seemed safe in childhood, had lied to her.

Ruth had grieved differently. She kept attending services, kept planting bulbs, kept bringing meals to other people. Mara mistook that persistence for forgetting. Their conversations grew cautious, then infrequent. It had been easier to describe her mother as devout than to

ask what her devotion cost her.

Mara carried the photograph downstairs and set it beside the blue envelope. She could hear the clock from the hallway. Grief, she realized, had not waited obediently where she left it. It had traveled with her, changing its clothes in each new apartment. She sat with the picture until the house became dark, and for once did not turn on music to fill the silence.

CHAPTER 04

Winter□s Last Work

Peter arrived on Thursday with a tin of tools and a thermos of tea. June came later, carrying gloves. They worked at the chapel gate while a wind moved through the hedges. Peter showed Mara how to support the iron leaf while he loosened the hinge pin. The work required patience rather than strength. Twice they stopped because the metal would not yield; twice Peter warmed his hands and began again.

As they worked, Peter spoke about Ruth without turning her into a saint. She could be stubborn, he said, and had once insisted the chapel roof be repaired before a proposed decorative window. 'People needed somewhere dry to sit,' he recalled. Mara laughed despite herself. It sounded like her mother. Peter added that Ruth had argued with him fiercely over the accounts and then brought him a jar of marmalade the next morning.

At noon a boy called Sam crossed the path with a bicycle missing its chain. He asked whether the chapel cupboard was open. Peter directed him to June, who found him a bag of groceries to take home. Mara saw how discreetly the exchange happened. No one asked the boy to explain his family's difficulties in public. June spoke to him about his bicycle

until he was ready to leave.

By afternoon the gate closed smoothly. Peter deliberately left the latch loose. 'It ought to close when it must,' he said, 'but people should be able to open it.' Mara held the gate once more, feeling its balanced weight. She had spent years making sure no one could enter the places where she was hurt. She had called the locks independence. Now she wondered whether a gate could protect without becoming a wall.

CHAPTER 05

The First Thaw

Rain arrived in March and stayed for three days. Water ran from the fields into the brook, turning it brown and loud. In the garden behind Ruth's house, snowdrops appeared beside a broken brick path. Mara had not known they were there. She found a notebook in the potting shed with her mother's sketches of the beds, the dates she had planted bulbs, and small observations about birds. On one page Ruth had written, 'Do not dig up what looks dead before you know the season.'

Mara took the notebook to June, who knew more about gardens than she did. June explained which shrubs could be cut back and which needed to be left alone. They worked for an hour, pulling away old stems and finding green shoots underneath. Their talk was easy until June mentioned Eli. She remembered him helping younger children across the flooded footbridge one spring. Mara felt the old impulse to leave.

Instead she said, 'Everyone here seems to have a story about him.' June stopped pulling weeds. 'You can ask us not to tell them,' she said. 'But he belonged to more than one memory.' Mara looked down at the soil on her gloves. The words hurt because they were true. She had tried to

preserve Eli by keeping him entirely private, as if other people's recollections could change what he meant to her.

That evening she wrote June's story in the back of Ruth's garden notebook. She did not write that it comforted her. She was not yet sure it did. But she wrote it carefully, because she did not want to forget it.

CHAPTER 06

A Place at the Table

The Wednesday meal at the chapel was held in a low room behind the sanctuary. A long table had been covered with mismatched cloths and bowls of lentil soup. Mara came because June asked her to carry plates. She planned to stay only until everyone was served. Then a woman named Agnes, whose hands trembled when she lifted her cup, asked Mara to sit beside her.

Agnes had known Ruth from the choir. She spoke of Ruth's terrible singing when she had a cold, of the time she lost her reading glasses and read an entire passage from memory, and of how she could make a person feel listened to even while washing dishes. Mara had prepared herself for pious tributes. These imperfect stories were harder to dismiss. They made her mother present in the room without pretending she had never been difficult.

Across the table Sam argued cheerfully with Peter about the best way to repair a bicycle. June was making notes for the reading hour. Nobody asked Mara what she believed. They asked whether she wanted more bread and whether she knew how to fix the kitchen cupboard at Ruth's house. She found herself answering questions about ordinary things.

When the dishes were done, Agnes pressed a small paper packet into her hand. Inside were marigold seeds Ruth had saved. 'She said you liked the bright ones when you were little,' Agnes told her. Mara could not remember that preference. She took the packet home and placed it beside the photograph of Eli. The table in the kitchen was beginning to hold things she had not intended to keep.

CHAPTER 07

The Letter Never Sent

In April Mara discovered an unsent letter tucked inside a book of poems. It was addressed to her, dated five years earlier. Ruth had written about Eli with a candor Mara had never heard from her. She admitted that there were mornings when faith felt like an empty room. She wrote that she did not know why he had died and had stopped asking herself to produce an answer. She attended chapel not because it erased the loss but because people there knew his name, and because she needed somewhere to bring her anger without pretending it had become peace.

Mara read the letter twice. She had believed her mother possessed a certainty that made grief easy. The letter described no such certainty. It described a woman who kept turning toward other people even when she could not turn her pain into a lesson. At the bottom Ruth had written that she was sorry for every time she had spoken too quickly about hope when Mara needed her simply to listen.

There was no explanation for why the letter had never been mailed. Perhaps Ruth had feared reopening a wound. Perhaps she had waited for the right moment until time ran out. Mara sat at the kitchen table with the paper spread flat before her. She wanted to ask her mother why

she had hidden so much of herself. She wanted to apologize for the years of distance. Both wishes were now impossible in the form she had imagined.

She walked to the chapel after sunset. The door was unlocked for the evening prayer hour, though only Peter sat in the last row. Mara did not join him. She stood near the entrance and let the quiet surround her. She did not know how to pray. She did know, for the first time in years, that her mother had not been praying against her grief. She had been praying inside it.

CHAPTER 08

Rain on the Chapel Roof

A storm struck Bellwether at the end of April. The wind lifted loose tiles from the chapel roof, and water came through the ceiling above the food cupboard. By morning boxes were damp, and the volunteers had moved everything they could save into the sanctuary. June called Mara to ask whether Ruth's shed could hold supplies while repairs were arranged. Mara said yes before she had calculated the inconvenience.

For two days her mother's house filled with people carrying bags of rice, tins, blankets, and folding tables. Sam helped label the shelves. Agnes counted packets with stern concentration. Peter made tea and worried aloud about the cost of repairs. Mara opened the garden door so the mud would stay out of the hallway, then stopped caring when the hallway became muddy anyway.

One afternoon June found her alone among the boxes. Mara admitted that she was frightened of becoming trapped in a life she had once fled. June did not argue. She said that helping for a season was not the same as promising forever. 'You can choose a next step without knowing the whole road,' she said. Mara thought of the years she had spent refusing any step that might make her vulnerable.

The chapel roof was patched by a local builder who offered part of his labor. The bill was still larger than the volunteers had hoped. At the meeting afterward, Mara proposed a village supper to raise money. Peter looked surprised. Mara was surprised too. She had come to close accounts, not to open another responsibility. Yet she heard herself volunteering to organize the tables.

CHAPTER 09

Summer□s Unfinished Song

By June the apple trees had filled with leaves, and the marigolds were small green plants in pots along the wall. Mara worked remotely from Ruth's kitchen for two days each week, traveling to the city when needed. She told herself the arrangement was temporary. Her colleagues accepted it more easily than she had expected. The freedom unsettled her; she had built much of her identity around believing she had no choices.

The village supper drew more people than the chapel room could hold. They set tables in the garden beneath strings of borrowed lights. Agnes supervised the serving with military precision. Sam repaired three bicycles that afternoon and insisted the work counted as his contribution. June organized a reading by the schoolchildren, who recited poems about weather and trees. Mara spent the evening carrying water jugs and collecting tickets, too busy to examine whether she belonged.

After the guests left, Peter found an old hymnbook and sang a few lines softly while stacking chairs. Mara recognized the tune from childhood. She remembered Ruth's voice, Eli tapping the table out of rhythm, and

the peculiar happiness of an evening that had required nothing remarkable to be good. The memory arrived with pain, but the pain did not erase the happiness.

The supper raised enough to cover the remaining repairs. June hugged Mara before she could step away. 'Your mother would have loved this,' she said, then added, 'And I think she would have loved seeing what you did with it.' Mara did not correct her. She walked home beneath a warm, clear sky, carrying a stack of folded tablecloths and a feeling she could not yet name.

CHAPTER 10

The Road Beyond the Bridge

In July Mara drove the road where Eli had died. She had avoided it since the funeral, though she knew the route as well as the lines of her hand. The bend was ordinary: a hedge, a low stone wall, a view of fields opening toward the hills. She parked at a safe lay-by and walked back along the verge. No sign marked the place. Wildflowers grew beside the ditch, indifferent to the meaning she had given it.

For years she had imagined that returning would make her collapse. Instead she felt tired and deeply present. She remembered the argument she and Eli had had the morning of the accident. She had told him he was careless; he had teased her for being afraid of everything. The words had become a private sentence she repeated whenever she felt joy, as if joy might prove she had not loved him enough.

She stood by the wall and spoke his name aloud. She said she was angry that he had died. She said she missed him. She said she was sorry for making their last conversation the whole story of their life together. The wind moved through the grass. Nothing answered in a voice. There was no sign, no sudden certainty, no explanation of what had happened.

On the drive home she stopped at the shop and bought strawberries. Eli had loved them. She ate some at the kitchen table and saved the rest for June. It was a small act, not a cure. But for the first time she allowed a memory of her brother to belong to the living day rather than only to the day he was lost.

CHAPTER 11

The Kindness of Boundaries

As summer deepened, Mara began to grow exhausted. She was helping with the chapel accounts, tending the garden, working her city job, and visiting Agnes, whose arthritis had worsened. Every request sounded small when made separately. Together they consumed her days. One evening she snapped at Sam when he left muddy tools beside the door. His face closed, and he took the tools away without speaking.

Mara found him the next morning and apologized. She had been unfair, she said. Sam shrugged and told her he was used to adults being cross. The answer made her feel worse. She asked if he would help her set up a proper place for tools so everyone could find them. They built a rack from spare wood and painted the labels together.

Later June told Mara that she could not be the answer to every need in Bellwether. Mara resisted the advice. She thought caring meant saying yes until nothing remained of herself. June pointed out that Ruth had learned to ask others for help, and that the chapel survived because people shared work rather than because one person carried it all. 'A door can be open,' June said, 'without every room belonging to everyone.'

Mara wrote a schedule and asked three volunteers to take turns with the accounts. She told Agnes she could visit on Saturdays but not every afternoon. Agnes accepted the arrangement without offense. Mara realized how often she had imagined other people's disappointment in advance and then punished herself for it. She began to understand that a generous life needed room for honesty.

CHAPTER 12

The Harvest Ledger

In September the apple trees bore more fruit than Mara knew how to use. Peter brought crates, June brought jars, and the schoolchildren helped collect the windfalls. Mara opened Ruth's notebook to the page marked harvest and found a list of names beside quantities of fruit. Her mother had divided each year's crop among households that needed it, the chapel kitchen, and neighbors who simply enjoyed apples. The ledger was both practical and tender.

They made preserves in the kitchen for two afternoons. Sam labeled the jars in handwriting that tilted uphill. Agnes judged the sweetness by taste and dismissed every suggestion of measuring. Mara laughed more than she had expected. When the work was done, they carried boxes to the chapel cupboard and set aside a basket for a family who had recently moved into the village.

The estate agent called with an offer for the house. It was fair, perhaps generous. Mara thanked him and asked for a week. She walked through each room afterward, considering what it would mean to sell. The house was not a museum. Keeping it could become another way of refusing change. Selling it would not erase her mother. She knew both things. She

also knew she was no longer the person who had arrived in February with a suitcase and a deadline.

That evening she sat beneath the apple tree with the letter Ruth had never sent. The garden smelled of fruit and damp leaves. Mara decided she would not sell before winter. It was not a promise to stay forever. It was a decision made with attention, rather than fear, and that made it different.

CHAPTER 13

The First Frost

The first frost silvered the garden in October. Agnes fell ill and spent several days in hospital. Mara visited with June, bringing a warm shawl and a book of poems. Agnes was annoyed by the food and grateful for the company. She told Mara not to make a tragedy of a short stay. Yet when Mara rose to leave, Agnes held her hand a little longer than usual.

Mara recognized the old terror of hospital corridors. Eli's death had made every medical uncertainty feel like a prediction. She went outside and stood beneath the awning, trying to breathe slowly. June followed but did not insist on conversation. After a while Mara said she had been praying again, though she did not know what she believed prayer could change. June said she sometimes prayed because she needed to tell the truth in the presence of God, not because she expected to control what happened next.

They returned to Agnes's room and found her asleep. The machines beside her bed made soft, ordinary sounds. Mara sat down with her book. She had once believed that faith was the ability to be certain. Now she wondered whether faith might sometimes be the decision to remain attentive when certainty was unavailable.

Agnes came home after a week, weaker but cheerful. Mara helped carry her bags inside. The relief was real, and so was the knowledge that other days might not end as they wished. Mara did not force the two truths to cancel one another. She went home and lit the lamp in Ruth's kitchen before the evening dark arrived.

CHAPTER 14

A Candle in the Window

On the anniversary of Ruth's death, Mara expected to feel a solemnity large enough to fill the house. Instead the morning was full of ordinary interruptions. A delivery arrived early. The kitchen tap began to drip. Sam called to ask whether he could borrow a screwdriver. Mara found herself irritated by the day for refusing to behave like a memorial.

She repaired the tap badly, then called Peter, who fixed it in ten minutes. Afterward they drank tea. He asked whether she wanted to talk about Ruth. Mara said she did, but did not know where to begin. Peter suggested she tell him something that had annoyed her mother. Mara remembered leaving wet shoes on the stairs and Ruth's elaborate speeches about the dangers of broken necks. They laughed, and then Mara cried. Peter sat with her until she could speak again.

That evening a few friends gathered at the chapel. There was no formal service, only a candle, some readings, and space for silence. Mara brought the unsent letter but did not read it aloud. She had begun to understand that not every private truth needed an audience. She spoke instead about Ruth's garden and the way she had kept a place at her table for people who needed one.

Afterward June walked home with her. The chapel gate swung quietly on its repaired hinge. Mara looked back at the candle glowing in the window. The light did not reach far across the fields. It did not need to. It was enough to show where the door was.

CHAPTER 15

Between Two Winters

December returned with low clouds and cold mornings. Mara spent a weekend in the city clearing her apartment. She did not give up her work or every familiar part of her old life. She arranged a smaller place near the office and agreed with her manager on a schedule that allowed longer stretches in Bellwether. It was a compromise, imperfect and workable. She had once regarded compromise as evidence that she had failed to choose. Now she saw it as a form of care for the different responsibilities she held.

Back in the village, the chapel prepared parcels for households facing a difficult winter. Mara helped with the accounts and then went home before she became tired enough to resent the work. She had learned to leave a task for another person. Sam took charge of collecting spare batteries for the torches. June organized a quiet reading hour for anyone who did not want the noise of the seasonal festivities.

On Christmas Eve, Mara visited Eli's grave with a small branch from the apple tree. She told him about the supper, the storm, the strawberries, and the boy who had finally learned to fix a bicycle chain. She told him that she had missed him every day, even when she pretended otherwise.

She did not ask him to forgive her for living. The words no longer seemed necessary.

Snow began as she walked home. At the chapel, the gate stood open. People were arriving in coats and scarves, carrying candles that would be lit inside. Mara joined them without feeling that she had to resolve every doubt before crossing the threshold. She sat near the back, where she could see the door and the winter darkness beyond it.

CHAPTER 16

The Prayer Between Seasons

In February, almost a year after her return, Mara walked the garden with Ruth's notebook. The apple trees were bare again. The marigolds had long since finished flowering, but she had saved their seeds in a paper envelope. She made a list of repairs for the spring and another of things she could leave alone. The distinction mattered to her now.

At the chapel she found Peter polishing the brass handle on the door. June was setting out books for the reading hour. Sam had grown taller and was explaining a complicated plan for building a shelter for bicycles. Agnes had sent a note asking everyone to stop worrying about her and bring marmalade instead. The village had not become perfect. There were disagreements about money, people who needed more help than the volunteers could give, and grief that no gathering could solve. It was a real place, and Mara loved it more for being real.

She stood alone for a moment in the chapel, where the afternoon light fell across the floor. She thought of Ruth and Eli, of the road beyond the bridge, of the letter she had found, and of the year that had changed her without erasing what had happened. She did not offer God a bargain. She did not ask for a future without loss. She prayed for courage to

receive the season she was in, wisdom to know what she could mend, and tenderness toward what could not be repaired.

Outside, the gate moved easily beneath her hand. Beyond the wall, the fields held the first signs of thaw. Mara walked home to the house at the end of the lane, where the kitchen clock was still keeping time and a packet of seeds waited beside the window.

EPILOGUE

The First Marigolds

Spring came quietly. There was no single day on which the village turned green, only a series of mornings when Mara noticed more light beneath the trees and softer ground along the path. She planted marigolds in the bed beside the kitchen door. June helped her carry compost. Sam arrived with a newly repaired bicycle and stayed for tea. Peter brought a jar of marmalade from Agnes, who had written on the label that it was not to be shared with anyone ungrateful.

Mara kept Ruth's notebook in the kitchen drawer. On the final page she began a record of her own: dates of planting, repairs still needed, names of people who had helped. She wrote that the first marigolds had opened on a Thursday. Then she added a sentence about Eli, who would have laughed at her seriousness and stolen the best strawberries before supper.

The house remained hers, for now. The city remained part of her life. Grief remained too, though it no longer demanded that every room be kept dark. She had learned that seasons do not cancel one another; they leave traces in the soil. On Sunday she walked through the chapel gate and held it for a woman she did not know. The woman thanked her and went inside. Mara followed, carrying no certainty about the years ahead,

but enough hope for the day she had been given.

STORY SUMMARY

A Prayer Between Seasons

After her mother's death, Mara Vale returns to the village she fled twelve years earlier, determined to sell the family house and leave. A damaged chapel gate, a garden notebook, and an unsent letter draw her into the lives of neighbors who remember both her mother and her late brother. Across winter, spring, summer, and autumn, Mara learns that faith need not explain grief, and that belonging does not require certainty. A Prayer Between Seasons concludes the Whispers of Grace series with a quiet story of reconciliation, honest prayer, boundaries, and the courage to begin again.

ABOUT THE IMPRINT

From The House of Christ Garden

From The House of Christ Garden publishes reflective stories of faith, love, endurance, and ordinary lives. Whispers of Grace is a collection of literary fiction exploring the ways compassion, hope, and spiritual courage take shape in daily choices. Each volume stands on its own while sharing the belief that grace is often encountered in quiet, unexpected places.

WHISPERS OF GRACE

The Four Books

Book I — The Mustard Seed Promise

Book II — The Chapel of Open Doors

Book III — Grace in the Waiting Room

Book IV — A Prayer Between Seasons